

H8314 שָׂרָף Pronunciation: sârâph saw-rawf' Derivation: from שָׂרַף; (H8313) Strong's: burning, i.e. (figuratively) poisonous (serpent); specifically, a saraph or symbolical creature (from their copper color) KJV: fiery (serpent), seraph.
H8313 שָׂרַף Pronunciation: sâraph saw-raf' Derivation: a primitive root; Strong's: to be (causatively, set) on fire KJV: (cause to, make a) burn((-ing), up) kindle, [idiom] utterly.

H8313 appears 117 times in the King James Bible and 112 times (or 96%) of those are one of the following: burn (39), burned (33), burneth (4), burnt (36).

A search on the world wide web for “which venomous snake bites create a burning sensation and are native to Israel and the Sinai peninsula” reveals the following:

There are only two known species of snakes native to Israel and the Sinai Peninsula whose venom causes an intense burning sensation by activating the TRPV1 pain receptors in humans (that is also activated by temperatures over 43°C, capsaicin, acidic pH, and inflammatory mediators such as cytokines, prostaglandins, histamine, kinins, and leukotrienes).

One of those snake species is called the “Painted saw-scaled viper” ([Echis coloratus](#)) but the other which is called the “Israeli mole viper” ([Atractaspis engaddensis](#)) is of particular interest because of the following:

- It's modern Hebrew name is "**Saraf** Ein Gedi" (see definitions for H8314 and H8313 above).
 - The modern Hebrew definition of “Saraf” is “burning or venomous serpent”.
- Even at high concentrations it's venom does not block contractions of skeletal muscles: In other words, after being bitten, you are still able to move your neck muscles and for example ... look at a brass serpent on a pole.
 - In God's instructions in [Numbers 21:9](#) the person was to look at the brass serpent *after* they were bitten. This would not normally be possible if the venom interfered with or prevented muscle movement (which is typical for highly venomous snake bites).
- It is categorized as having “**very high** lethal potency” with an i.v. LD50 of 0.06-0.075 micro-grams per gram of body weight in mice. The venom's varied and nasty effects begin [within minutes](#) in humans.
 - It's venom is 29 times more potent than a member of the same family the Dahomey burrowing asp ([Atractaspis dahomeyensis](#)) and 36 to 45 times more potent than the [western diamondback rattlesnake](#) on the lowest end (intravenous injection).
- There is currently **no antivenom** available for this snakes venom.
- We are still unsure of exactly how the venom kills a person (“seemingly [from] neurotoxic effects”) and reports of people surviving bites are actually more common than reports of deaths (apparently due to those being reported having the fangs of the snake not penetrating deep enough into the skin).
- In an [Israeli news article from 2022-08-19](#) (written in modern Hebrew: <https://www.kolhair.co.il/health/104912/>) it is described as “the most venomous snake in the country, against which there is no serum”.
 - The heart of the 3 year old that was bitten stopped beating, among other complications, and needless to say without swift medical assistance she would have quickly died.
- Based on the evidence, if the snake gets a good, deep bite on you, and someone isn't around to keep your heart pumping you would likely die within minutes (you will very likely be unconscious within minutes regardless).